

Scene 1: The Hidden Grove - The Order's Call

TIME

~15 minutes

PURPOSE

- Introduction and character creation
- Establish mission and stakes
- Blade-bearer selection
- Gifting ceremony

SETTING

Secret meeting place in ancient forest. Massive trees form natural cathedral. Golden light filters through leaves. Air hums with Spirit of Life presence.

OPENING NARRATION

A secret meeting place deep in the ancient forest, where massive trees form a natural cathedral. Soft golden light filters through leaves, and the air hums with the presence of the Spirit of Life.

You arrive one by one, each having received mysterious summons. An elder figure awaits you - Elder Greymane, wise and patient, bearing a staff carved with ancient symbols.

Elder Greymane:

Welcome, young ones. You have been called here because the Spirit of Life stirs within you. Each of you carries something precious - not earned, but given freely. Today, you begin a journey that will test not just your strength, but your hearts.

PLAYER INTRODUCTIONS

- Have each child introduce themselves
- Ask: What's your name? Tell us something you're proud of or something you love
- Let them be silly or serious - whatever feels right
- Elder Greymane responds warmly to each one

MISSION BRIEFING

The great fortress city of Rjocht has fallen into shadow. One of Drachan's generals - a creature named Dorogh - holds the people in fear and cruelty. The city fell at the end of the First Age, and now in the dawn of the Third Age, we are called to reclaim it.

The people suffer under unrighteous judgment, enslaved and broken by Dorogh's rule. You must free them.

THE BLADE OF RIGHTEOUS JUDGMENT

[Elder Greymane unwraps an artifact - massive curved blade, bone-white, etched with glowing script]

Elder Greymane:

This is the Blade of Righteous Judgment. Long ago, it was one of the great Tools of Justice, forged for the protection of all creation. But at the end of the First Age, Drachan twisted it, made it part of himself - a tooth among his many fangs. In that same darkness, the great fortress city of Rjocht fell.

When the Warrior King struck Drachan down in the Second Age, the Blade was reclaimed. Restored. Made righteous again.

Only this weapon can pierce Dorogh's heart and break his hold on the city. But to carry it requires sacrifice. The bearer will hold nothing else - no other weapon, no tools, no provisions. The weight is impossibly heavy, but your gifting in this journey shall be to bear it lightly and for as long as it takes.

The Blade will guide you - when evil draws near, you will feel it run cold as winter ice.

This is not a burden for the strongest, but for the most faithful. Who among you will bear this?

THE CHOICE

- Let silence sit for a moment
- One child will volunteer (or party discusses)
- When chosen, Elder Greymane places Blade in their hands with both of his

Elder Greymane (to blade-bearer):

Do you feel it? The weight? That is judgment itself. But the Spirit of Life will give you strength. Your gift is this: to carry what would crush another. To bear it lightly. To wield it truly. The Warrior King sees you, and he is well pleased.

GIFTING CEREMONY

[To the group] Now, all others will be given gifts as well. Each of you has been touched by the Spirit of Life in different ways. These gifts are not earned - they are given freely, because you are loved and chosen.

CHARACTER CREATION - BLADE-BEARER

- Receives ONLY: Blade of Righteous Judgment card + Strange Bun card
- No ability cards, no weapon, no other items
- Their gift is to carry the burden

CHARACTER CREATION - OTHERS

- Draw 3 ability cards, choose 2, discard 1
- Draw 1 weapon card
- Draw 1 item card
- Can trade weapons & items (not abilities)
- Elder Greymane can comment on choices warmly

THE BLESSING

[Elder Greymane places hand on each player's head/shoulder]

To blade-bearer:

May your burden be light as a feather, though it weighs as the world. May your aim be true, and may you strike only when the moment is right. The King goes with you.

To each other player:

May your [ability] serve the light. May you find what you need when you need it most.

To all:

When you feel warmth in your hearts, you walk the right path. When the Blade runs cold, evil is near. Trust each other. Trust the King. Go now, children of the Third Age. Reclaim what was lost. Free those who suffer. Show Dorogh and all who serve Drachan that the Warrior King has not forgotten Rjocht.

DEPARTURE

Players set off together through the ancient forest, the Blade-bearer at the center of their company, carrying judgment toward the fallen city.

TRANSITION

The road ahead leads through wilderness toward Rjocht. Journey will take a day. First stop: the Crossroads Inn.